

WA.2 Permit Application Checklist

Everything a Washington owner-builder gathers, verifies, and files — with the state-level gates that stop an application cold, and the clocks the State puts on your reviewer once it is complete.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Washington's building code is written by the State and enforced locally by 39 counties and hundreds of cities and towns, each with its own forms and fees — and your electrical permit may come from a different agency altogether. Confirm every item with the department that will issue your permit before you rely on it.

THE FOUR GATES SET BY STATE LAW

Most of what your city or county asks for is local. These four are not — they are conditions Washington law puts on your application, and no local office can waive them. Clear these before you worry about anything else.

- **1. Proof of water.** Every applicant for a building permit for a building needing potable water must *"provide evidence of an adequate water supply for the intended use of the building."* In 15 named water resource inventory areas the proof is defined by rule and comes with a fee and a withdrawal cap. (RCW 19.27.097(1))
- **2. A complete application — which is worth more than an early one.** Completeness is what freezes the rules in your favor and what starts your reviewer's clock. The statute lists what the application must contain. (RCW 19.27.095(1), (2); RCW 36.70B.070)
- **3. Energy credits shown on the drawings.** *"The drawings included with the building permit application shall identify which options have been selected and the point value of each option"* — a submission requirement written into the energy code itself. (WAC 51-11R-40620, § R406.3)
- **4. Your electrical permit is not on this application.** The residential code sends electrical work to a different rule book: *"Electrical Code is regulated by chapter 296-46B WAC or Electrical Code as adopted by the local jurisdiction."* See **WA.3** and **WA.4**. (WAC 51-51-003)

File complete, not fast — RCW 19.27.095(1)

"A valid and fully complete building permit application for a structure, that is permitted under the zoning or other land use control ordinances in effect on the date of the application shall be considered under the building permit ordinance in effect at the time of application, and the zoning or other land use control ordinances in effect on the date of application."

This is Washington's vesting rule, and it is a real protection: a code change, a fee increase, or a new zoning overlay that lands after your complete application does not reach your project. It attaches to **completeness**, not to the date you first walked in. An incomplete application buys you nothing.

A. SITE AND PROJECT VERIFICATION**A1: Before anything else**

	Item	Date	Notes / who confirmed
☐	Confirmed which office issues your building permit — city or town if you are inside the limits, otherwise the county (see WA.4)		
☐	Confirmed separately who issues your electrical permit — L&I, or a city or county running its own electrical program		
☐	Parcel number and site address confirmed Parcel #: _____ Address: _____		
☐	Deed recorded in your name — the contractor-registration exemption you are relying on is an <i>own property</i> exemption		
☐	Zoning, permitted use, and setbacks confirmed in writing Front: _____ Side: _____ Rear: _____ Other: _____		
☐	Critical areas and shoreline jurisdiction checked — wetlands, streams, steep slopes, geologic hazard, floodplain, and any shoreline designation under chapter 90.58 RCW. This is the most common cause of a long Washington permit		
☐	Easements, rights-of-way, recorded restrictions, and any HOA or covenant approval identified — covenants are private, and nobody checks them for you		

B. THE APPLICATION PACKAGE

For any construction project costing more than **\$5,000**, RCW 19.27.095(2) fixes a minimum content list for the application: the legal description or tax parcel number and the street address; the property owner's name, address and phone; **the prime contractor's business name, address, phone and current state contractor registration number**; and either the lender administering interim construction financing or the firm that issued a payment bond. Those details are then printed on the permit itself and on the inspection record card posted at the site.

The line that stops owner-builders: "prime contractor's ... registration number"

You are exempt from contractor registration on your own property, so you have no number to write. This is normal and every Washington permit counter has seen it — they will have you identify yourself as the owner-builder, and many use an owner-builder acknowledgment form for exactly this. Ask which form they want *before* you file, and do not leave the box blank without asking.

Separately, RCW 19.27.095(5): if the lender or payment-bond information is not yet available, you say so, the application "*shall be processed forthwith*," and it "*shall not cause the application to be deemed incomplete for the purposes of vesting*."

B1: Forms and proofs

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Building permit application, completed and signed		
☐	Owner-builder acknowledgment / exemption form as your jurisdiction words it — ask for it by name		
☐	Evidence of adequate water supply attached (see section C) Form of evidence: _____		
☐	Estimated construction cost stated — this usually sets your fee Stated cost: \$ _____		
☐	Lender or payment-bond details supplied, or their absence stated in writing		
☐	Separate trade permits identified: plumbing and mechanical from your building department; electrical from L&I or the local electrical program		

B2: Plans and supporting drawings

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Complete plan sets in the number and format your jurisdiction requires (most Washington jurisdictions now take digital submission)		
☐	Site plan showing property lines, setbacks, building footprint, driveway, well and septic areas including the reserve area , critical areas and their buffers, and easements		
☐	Foundation plan, floor plans, elevations, wall sections, framing plan		
☐	Energy credit options and their point values shown on the drawings — required by § R406.3, not optional Credits shown: _____		
☐	Local Table R301.2 design criteria obtained and used — ground snow load, wind, seismic design category, frost depth Snow: _____ Wind: _____ SDC: _____ Frost: _____		
☐	Engineered details where the code needs them — lateral bracing and hold-downs in the higher seismic categories, trusses, long spans, retaining walls, steep-slope foundations		

You are allowed to draw your own house

Washington's architect practice act does not reach houses. RCW 18.08.410 says the chapter shall not prevent "*any person from doing design work including preparing construction contract documents and administration of the construction contract for the erection, enlargement, repair, or alteration of a structure or any appurtenance to a structure **regardless of size**, if the structure is to be used for a residential building of up to and including four dwelling units.*"

So no architect's stamp is required by the licensing statute, at any square footage. That is **not** the same as saying no engineering is required: where the building code calls for calculations — and much of western Washington sits in a seismic design category that does — you still need them. The distinction is license versus code.

C. WATER — THE GATE MOST OWNER-BUILDERS TRIP OVER

If your house needs potable water, you cannot get a building permit without proving you will have it. Acceptable evidence is *"a water right permit from the department of ecology, a letter from an approved water purveyor stating the ability to provide water, or another form sufficient to verify the existence of an adequate water supply."* And one sentence that has cost people a building season: *"An application for a water right shall not be sufficient proof of an adequate water supply."*

"Washington lets you drill a well for 5,000 gallons a day" — not where most people build

The often-quoted figure is real: RCW 90.44.050 exempts from permitting a groundwater withdrawal *"for single or group domestic uses in an amount not exceeding five thousand gallons a day,"* plus watering a lawn or non-commercial garden up to half an acre. That is the statewide baseline.

But in **15 water resource inventory areas** the 2018 streamflow-restoration law replaced it. In WRIAs 7 (Snohomish), 8 (Cedar-Sammamish), 9 (Duwamish-Green), 10 (Puyallup-White), 12 (Chambers-Clover), 13 (Deschutes), 14 (Kennedy-Goldsborough) and 15 (Kitsap), a new permit-exempt domestic connection is capped at **950 gallons per day** — indoor use for a household, and little else — with a **\$500 fee** paid to the permitting authority and a requirement to manage stormwater on site. In WRIAs 1 (Nooksack), 11 (Nisqually), 22 (Lower Chehalis), 23 (Upper Chehalis), 49 (Okanogan), 55 (Little Spokane) and 59 (Colville), the cap is **3,000 gallons per day**, again with the \$500 fee. That first list is the Puget Sound population — if your lot is in one of those basins and your plan assumed 5,000 gallons a day and no fee, both halves of the plan are wrong.

RCW 19.27.097(1)(a)–(d); RCW 90.44.050; RCW 90.94.020(5)(f) and RCW 90.94.030(3). Both caps apply *"until rules have been adopted that specify otherwise"* — Ecology has been adopting basin rules since, so **confirm the current figure for your WRIA with Ecology or your permit counter**. Additional rules apply in WRIAs 3 and 4 (Skagit) under chapter 173-503 WAC following *Swinomish Indian Tribal Community v. Department of Ecology*, and in WRIAs 37, 38 and 39 (Yakima) where adjudicated rights govern. Find your WRIA on Ecology's water resources map at ecology.wa.gov.

C1: Water supply

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Water resource inventory area (WRIA) for your parcel identified WRIA #: _____ Name: _____		
☐	Determined which applies: public water purveyor, permit-exempt well, or an existing water right		

C1: Water supply

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	If public water: written letter from the purveyor stating ability to serve obtained Purveyor: _____ Date: _____		
☐	If a well: confirmed whether your WRIA carries a reduced withdrawal cap, a \$500 fee, and a restriction recorded against title — and budgeted all three		
☐	Well driller licensed under chapter 18.104 RCW, and the well report understood to be part of your permit evidence		

D. SEPTIC — YOUR LOCAL HEALTH JURISDICTION, NOT THE BUILDING OFFICE

On-site sewage is permitted and inspected by your **local health officer** under a statewide Department of Health rule, on a separate track and a separate timeline from your building permit. Except for a minor repair, *"a person proposing the installation ... of an OSS, shall submit an application and obtain a permit from the local health officer prior to beginning construction."* The application must carry the soil and site evaluation, a dimensioned site plan showing both the initial and the **reserve** area, and a detailed design bearing the **name, signature and stamp of the designer**.

Two timing facts worth planning around: the local health officer must **respond to an application within 30 days**, and the permit's expiration date *"may not exceed five years from the date of permit issuance."* Start the soil evaluation before anything else on this list — it is the item most likely to change what you can build, or whether you can build at all.

You may be allowed to install it yourself — ask

"Only installers may construct OSS," with one exception: *"The local health officer **may allow** the resident owner of a single-family residence to install the OSS for that single-family residence"* — except where the primary and reserve areas are within **200 feet of marine water**, within **100 feet of surface water**, or the permit meets the Table X standards of WAC 246-272A-0280.

Note *may allow*. This is a discretion your health officer exercises, not a right you hold, and the water setbacks rule out a great many Puget Sound lots. If you get permission, the rule then binds you the same way it binds a professional: follow the approved design, keep it on site, change nothing without the designer's and the health officer's prior authorization, be **on site at all times during excavation and construction**, and **do not cover the system until the health officer has approved covering it**.

WAC 246-272A-0200(2), (4)(a), (4)(f) and WAC 246-272A-0250(1)-(3), chapter 246-272A WAC (On-site Sewage Systems), read at app.leg.wa.gov August 2026. The 30-day response duty traces to RCW 70.05.074.

Application forms, fees, and any additional local rules are set by your local health jurisdiction under WAC 246-272A-0013 — confirm them there, not here.

D1: On-site sewage

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Local health jurisdiction for your county identified (see WA.4) — it is often not the same agency as your building department		
☐	Soil and site evaluation completed By: _____ Date: _____		
☐	Design prepared and stamped by a licensed designer, or written permission to prepare your own confirmed with the health officer Designer: _____		
☐	Initial and reserve areas shown on the site plan and consistent with the house footprint, driveway and well		
☐	Septic permit issued Permit #: _____ Expires: _____		
☐	If installing it yourself: written permission from the health officer, and the marine/surface water setbacks confirmed not to apply		
☐	Pre-cover inspection scheduled, and any operational permit or ongoing monitoring requirement understood		

E. CODE EDITIONS AND ENERGY COMPLIANCE

Washington's building code is not optional anywhere: *"Except as otherwise provided in this chapter, there shall be in effect in **all counties and cities** the state building code."* The residential stack in force is the **2021** International Residential Code as adopted and amended by chapter 51-51 WAC, with the energy code in chapter 51-11R WAC and plumbing in chapter 51-56 WAC. Note that Washington adopts the **Uniform Plumbing Code**, not the International Plumbing Code — buy the right book.

RCW 19.27.031(1); WAC 51-51-003, which adopts the 2021 IRC "provided that chapters 11 and 25 through 43 of this code are not adopted" and sends energy, plumbing and electrical to their own chapters. Washington runs a three-year adoption cycle (RCW 19.27.031(3)); confirm the edition your jurisdiction is enforcing before you draw. Verified August 2026.

Three things Washington did to the residential code

No sprinkler mandate for your house. The IRC's one- and two-family sprinkler section is struck: "*R313.2 One- and two-family dwellings automatic sprinkler systems. This section is not adopted.*" Townhouse units do require them — except in townhouse buildings of no more than four units. (WAC 51-51-0313)

Radon control is broader than the map. Appendix F applies in the high radon potential (zone 1) counties named in the code's own Table AF101(1) — *and "to all buildings constructed using the provisions of Section R408.3 Unvented crawl space compliance method."* Choose a conditioned crawl space anywhere in Washington and you have opted into radon control. (WAC 51-51-0332)

Your local design criteria are genuinely local. "*Additional criteria shall be established by the local jurisdiction and set forth in Table R301.2.*" Snow load, wind, seismic design category and frost depth come from your building department, not from a statewide table. Get them in writing before you engineer anything. (WAC 51-51-0301)

The energy code is where Washington earns its reputation — and where the prescriptive table is simpler than you expect. All 39 counties sit in just two climate zones, **4C** (marine, west of the Cascades) or **5B** (dry, east) — there is no zone 6 in the code's Washington table. And the prescriptive envelope table has a **single column**, headed "Climate Zone 5 and Marine 4," so the numbers are the same whether you build in Bellingham or Walla Walla.

WSEC-R Table R402.1.3 — prescriptive minimums, the whole state

Component	Requirement	What the footnote adds
Fenestration <i>U</i> -factor	0.30	0.32 permitted above 4,000 ft elevation (note j)
Skylight <i>U</i> -factor	0.50	
Ceiling	R-60	R-38 permitted for single rafter- or joist-vaulted ceilings where the full depth extends over the top plate (note e)
Wood frame wall	R-20+5 or R-13+10	First figure is cavity, second is continuous insulation (note i)
Floor	R-30	
Below-grade wall	R-10/15/21 int + 5TB	R-5 thermal break between floor slab and basement wall (note c)
Slab	R-10, 4 ft	R-10 continuous required under heated slabs (note d)

WAC 51-11R-40213, Table R402.1.3, as amended effective March 15, 2024 (WSR 24-03-084). *R*-values are minimums and *U*-factors are maximums. This is the prescriptive path only — R405 total building performance and R407 certified passive house are separate routes with different paperwork. County climate zones are in WAC 51-11R-30100, Table R301.1; geography will mislead you, so look yours up rather than guessing — **Skamania is 5B** despite sitting on the west side.

Then the credits. On top of the envelope, every dwelling unit must "*comply with sufficient options ... so as to achieve the following minimum number of credits*": **5.0** for a small dwelling unit (under 1,500 sq ft of conditioned floor area with less than 300 sq ft of fenestration), **8.0** for a medium dwelling unit (everything not otherwise listed), and **9.0** for a large dwelling unit (over 5,000 sq ft of conditioned floor area). This is the requirement that drives heat pumps, heat pump water heaters and better envelopes into Washington houses, and it is the one to design around early — the options you pick change your mechanical system, not just your insulation.

WAC 51-11R-40620, § R406.3.

Washington makes you pass three tests, not one

1 — Blower door, and there is no visual alternative. "*The building or dwelling unit shall be tested for air leakage.*" The limit: "*The maximum air leakage rate for any dwelling unit **under any compliance path** shall not exceed 4.0 air changes per hour,*" at 50 Pa. A signed written report, with the verified location and a time stamp, goes to you and to the code official. (§ R402.4.1.2, § R402.4.1.3.1)

2 — Duct leakage. "*Ducts shall be leak tested.*" Rough-in: 4.0 cfm per 100 sq ft of conditioned floor area at 25 Pa, or 3.0 if the air handler is not yet installed. Post-construction: 4.0 cfm per 100 sq ft. Ducts and air handlers entirely inside the thermal envelope: 8.0 cfm per 100 sq ft — and **ducts in a crawl space do not qualify** for that allowance. (§ R403.3.5, § R403.3.6)

3 — Ventilation airflow, the one people forget. "*Mechanical ventilation systems shall be tested and verified to provide the minimum ventilation flow rates required,*" with a signed written report to the code official. Whole-house mechanical ventilation is required in the first place. (§ R403.6, § R403.6.2)

WAC 51-11R-40240, WAC 51-11R-40320 and WAC 51-11R-40350 — the 2021 Washington State Energy Code, Residential, effective March 15, 2024. Book the testing agency early; in rural counties there are few of them and they set your schedule, not the other way round.

E1: Energy code

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Compliance path chosen — prescriptive, total building performance (R405), or certified passive house (R407) Path: _____		
☐	Climate zone for your county looked up in Table R301.1 Climate zone: _____		

E1: Energy code

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Dwelling size category and required credits determined; options chosen and printed on the drawings with their point values Size: _____ Credits: _____		
☐	Insulation, window U-factor and air-sealing details shown on the plans		
☐	All three tests booked — blower door (4.0 ACH50), duct leakage, ventilation airflow Tester: _____ Booked: _____		

F. WHAT THE STATE GUARANTEES YOU

Washington gives an applicant more leverage than most states, and almost none of it is volunteered at the counter. These apply to jurisdictions planning under the Growth Management Act, which covers most of the state's population — ask whether yours does.

- **28 days to tell you whether you are complete.** The local government must give you a written determination that the application is procedurally complete or say exactly what is missing. If they say nothing, *"an application shall be deemed procedurally complete on the 29th day."* (RCW 36.70B.070(1), (4)(a))
- **Then a decision clock.** From the determination of completeness: **65 days** for a permit needing no public notice, **100 days** with notice, **170 days** with notice and a hearing. Time spent waiting on *you* does not count. (RCW 36.70B.080(1)(d), (g))
- **Your money back if they miss it.** *"When permit time periods ... are not met, a portion of the permit fee must be refunded"* — **10%** if the overrun is within 20% of the original period, **20%** beyond that. A jurisdiction may instead collect only 80% of the fee up front and bill the rest if it hits its dates. (RCW 36.70B.080(1)(l))
- **Local residential amendments need State approval.** *"No amendment to a code enumerated in RCW 19.27.031 ... that affects single-family or multifamily residential buildings shall be effective unless the amendment is approved by the building code council."* If you are told a local rule requires something the State code does not, you may ask whether the Council approved it. (RCW 19.27.060(1)(a))

The refund provision does not apply to a jurisdiction that has implemented at least three of the process options in RCW 36.70B.160(1) — ask which applies to yours. Excluded from the clock: time waiting on requested information, an applicant-requested suspension, environmental impact statement preparation, and appeal periods (RCW 36.70B.080(1)(g)). Verified August 2026.

Application filed: _____ Determined complete: _____

Decision due: _____ Permit #: _____

Sources — every Washington claim in this document (verified August 2026)

What this document states	Authority
State building code is in effect in all counties and cities; the adopted model codes include the Uniform Plumbing Code	RCW 19.27.031(1)
A local amendment affecting single-family residential is ineffective unless approved by the State Building Code Council	RCW 19.27.060(1)(a)
A complete application vests to the ordinances in effect on the application date	RCW 19.27.095(1)
Application contents over \$5,000, including the prime contractor's registration number; missing lender/bond data does not break vesting	RCW 19.27.095(2), (5)
Evidence of an adequate water supply required; a water right application is not sufficient proof; the WRIA lists	RCW 19.27.097(1)
Permit-exempt domestic groundwater baseline of 5,000 gallons per day	RCW 90.44.050
Reduced caps and a \$500 fee: 3,000 gpd in WRIAs 1, 11, 22, 23, 49, 55, 59; 950 gpd plus on-site stormwater in WRIAs 7, 8, 9, 10, 12, 13, 14, 15	RCW 90.94.020(5)(f); 90.94.030(3)
Anyone may do the design work for a residential building of up to four dwelling units, regardless of size	RCW 18.08.410(5)
28 days to a completeness determination, deemed complete on day 29; then 65/100/170-day decision clocks and the 10%/20% fee refund	RCW 36.70B.070(1), (4)(a); 36.70B.080(1)(d), (l)
2021 IRC adopted; electrical regulated by chapter 296-46B WAC or the local jurisdiction's electrical code	WAC 51-51-003
One- and two-family sprinkler section not adopted; radon Appendix F in zone 1 counties and in any unvented crawl space house	WAC 51-51-0313; 51-51-0332
Local jurisdiction sets Table R301.2 design criteria; all 39 counties are climate zone 4C or 5B, and one prescriptive envelope column covers the whole state	WAC 51-51-0301; 51-11R-30100; 51-11R-40213
Three mandatory tests: air leakage at 4.0 ACH50 under any compliance path, duct leakage, and verified ventilation airflow	WAC 51-11R-40240; -40320; -40350
Energy credits: 5.0 small, 8.0 medium, 9.0 large; options shown on the drawings	WAC 51-11R-40620
Septic permit from the local health officer before construction; 30-day response; permit not to exceed five years	WAC 246-272A-0200
Resident owner may be allowed to install their own system, with water setback exclusions	WAC 246-272A-0250

Read any statute cited above at app.leg.wa.gov/RCW/default.aspx?cite=18.27.090, and any rule at app.leg.wa.gov/WAC/default.aspx?cite=296-46B-925, with the chapter and section swapped in. All RCW and WAC text in this kit was read there and verified August 2026.